

Committee	United Nations- Human Rights Council
Agenda Item	Safeguarding the human rights of journalists operating in situations of armed conflict
Main Submitter	State of Qatar
Co Submitter	Argentine Republic, Kingdom of Netherlands, Ukraine
Signatories	Federal Republic of Germany, Dominion of Canada, United Kingdom, Romania, Republic of South Africa, French Republic, Republic of the Philippines, Kingdom of Sweden, Republic of Kenya

Recognizing the importance of freedom of expression and of free, independent, plural and diverse media, online as well as offline, in building and supporting the functioning of inclusive societies and democracies, an informed citizenry, the rule of law and participation in public affairs and in holding public institutions and officials accountable, including by exposing corruption,

Noting the bravery of journalists operating in armed conflicts,

Recognizing that journalists are civilians and must receive full protection under International Humanitarian Law,

Condemning unequivocally any measure that prevents or disrupts an individual's ability to receive or impart information online or offline, including partial or complete Internet shutdowns,

Reaffirming the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, and recalling relevant international human rights treaties, including the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights and the International Convention for the Protection of All Persons from Enforced Disappearance, as well as the Geneva Conventions of 1949 and the Additional Protocols thereto of 8 June 1977,

Recognizing the importance of all forms of the media, including the printed media, radio, television and the Internet, in the exercise, promotion and protection of the right to freedom of opinion and expression,

Reaffirming that everyone has the right to life, liberty and security of person,

Underlining the important role of regional and subregional organizations in the safety of journalists,

Deeply regretting the passing of beloved journalists in active war zones,

1. 1. **Endorses** member states to exert sustained diplomatic pressure on states that do not enforce strict policies regarding the safety of journalists in conflict zones by:
 - a. implementing targeted diplomatic sanctions against states or organisations found to be responsible for targeting, harassing or unlawfully detaining media personnel,
 - b. using trade agreements and foreign aid as incentives for the adherence to international human rights standards,
 - c. holding states accountable for domestic legal frameworks, or lack thereof, that fail to protect foreign or local journalists in areas of active hostility;
2. **Recommends** the establishment of an international monitoring system to track and document human rights violations regarding media professionals:
 - a. differentiating legitimate journalists from combatants or state propagandists, ensuring that no aggressor country or terrorist group can justify the killing of journalists by claiming it was a military target,
 - b. formerly recognizing attacks on media workers in radio and internet infrastructure as a violation of the free speech,
 - c. protecting journalists from cyber crimes, specifically doxxing, which violates the right to privacy of personal information, therefore putting the media worker at risk;
3. **Proposes** the creation of a special branch of military officers who are specifically tasked with coordinating the press in active conflict zones by:
 - a. using drones controlled by each member state government in order to see if the region of conflict is safe for journalists to investigate
 - b. taking into consideration the past actions in that region,using advanced equipment to guide the journalists to the area of conflict,
 - c. making sure to safely transport the journalists near the zone of conflict with the help of military automobiles;
4. **Calls for** the development and funding of the Journalist Safety Digital Program (JSDP) aimed at helping media workers acquire useful skills such as:
 - a. specialised digital security training, in order to minimise the risks of surveillance, hacking, and geolocation tracking by state and non-state actors,

- b. survival and first-aid capabilities specifically tailored to the high-stress environments of active war-zones,
 - c. risk assessment strategies that help journalists correctly evaluate the level of risk of the situation and promote informed decision making;
- 5. **Suggests** creating a cybersecure platform for journalists all over the world, taking into account the current status of censorship, forced publications and coercions in the field of journalism at the moment, in accordance of each states' sovereignty, offering:
 - a. full privacy and the option to keep anonymity for all media workers, safeguarding them from any possible threats,
 - b. the possibility of publishing content freely, with no restrictions or governmental interventions, allowing:
 - i. uncensored content to be published,
 - ii. previously deleted content to be republished,
 - iii. ability to shed light on the realities of current political situations;
- 6. **Proposes** the foundation of an UN-led organization called “The Global Journalist Lobby”, with the purpose of:
 - a. offering journalists a protected, anonymous space of reporting all forms of corruption, discrimination, or crimes against humanity, without the fear of being convicted,
 - b. offering psychological aid for journalists who experienced trauma in zones of conflicts,
 - c. promoting the vital role of journalists on social media platforms in exposing worldwide corruption and crimes against humanity,
 - d. promoting the “International Day to End Impunity” for Crimes against journalists” on the 2nd of November to raise awareness;
- 7. **Seeks** the creation of centers where advanced technological equipment will be given to journalists with the help of a database, taking into consideration:
 - a. that the centers will be built near the regions where the journalists are most affected by conflicts,
 - b. the collaboration with NGOs and volunteers, which will:
 - i. put in the database the time the journalists have left and returned to the centers,
 - ii. help give the journalists the right sizes for the equipment,
 - iii. provide aid for the journalists in need,
 - c. that the centers will have implemented medical rooms with the purpose of:

- i. making sure the journalists are in stable condition to go investigate the conflict zone,
 - ii. making sure the journalists have not been hurt after coming back to the centers,
 - iii. finding out if the journalists suffer of any neurological conditions which can lead to them being hurt in the conflict zone,
 - iv. seeing if the journalists have any phobias which can lead to them not being able to do their job;
- 8. **Invites** the International Financial Institutions, including the International Monetary Fund, hereinafter IMF, and World Bank, as well as voluntary contributions from member states, to support funding mechanisms for journalist protection initiatives, taking into account:
 - a. regional needs and risk levels,
 - b. transparency and accountability in fund allocation,
 - c. collaboration with existing international programs supporting press freedom;
- 9. **Encourages** financing proper investigations, in order to lower impunity against media workers, conducted by professional investigators, focusing on:
 - a. creating a comprehensive database to record instances of harassment, kidnaping, injury and murder of journalists,
 - b. providing legal resources and assistance to local judicial bodies to ensure that crimes against journalists are properly investigated, and that the perpetrators are held accountable,
 - c. publishing annual reports detailing the compliance of states with international safety standards for press;
- 10. **Proclaims** member states to prioritize the de-escalation of active hostilities and the resolution of territorial disputes through diplomatic actions, in order to protect civilian lives, by:
 - a. engaging in mediated negotiations to shrink the geographical component of active combat zones, therefore reducing the total area where journalists and other civilians are at risk,
 - b. integrating specific media protection clauses into formal ceasefire agreements to ensure that journalists are granted safe passage for the duration of these agreements,
 - c. recognising that preserving a free and safe press is fundamental for long-term stability and recovery in any region emerging from conflict;
- 11.
- 12. 11. **Further recommends** the organization of advocacy events by “The Global Journalist Lobby” branches in cities worldwide, in order to spread awareness of the modern day hardships in journalism, including educational

campaigns presented by journalists who have been to conflict areas, based on their personal experiences, with the purpose of raising awareness and appreciation on the independent media workers

13.

14. 12. **Suggests** the implementation of secure and adaptable IT tools to establish digital protection, network and digital isolation, and encrypted communication to ensure the abolishment of spyware systems of reporters, while respecting national sovereignty and the different technological capacities of member states, by carrying out:

- a. a) end-to-end encryption protocols such as asymmetric encryption, perfect forward secrecy and disappearing messages,
- b. b) virtual private networks and client isolation,
- c. c) specialized anti-malware scans, mandatory updates and monitoring data usage;

13. **Proposes** the establishment of emergency visas or asylum pathways for threatened journalists:

- a. establishing fast-track visa procedures for journalists facing imminent threats in conflict zone,
- b. ensuring that family members of threatened journalists are also eligible for protection and relocation,
- c. providing temporary relocation programs with access to housing, healthcare and legal assistance;

15. **Invites** the International Federation of Journalists (IFJ) Safety Fund to remove the economical obstacles that inhibits the media coverage and to protect local “fixers” and translators that are generally less safeguarded, the socio-economic stability of reporters and their families by providing financial support, access to insurance and emergency funds, by:

- a. providing financial support,
- b. guaranteeing access to insurance and emergency funds also to freelance journalists,
- c. being subsidized by any willing member state and other international funds such as RSF with capital to be designated subsequently;

16. **Recommends** the strengthening of cooperation with the International Criminal Court (ICC) to take immediate action against aggressor countries that have systematically killed journalists and destroyed media and internet infrastructure of invaded countries, with the purpose of criminalizing the state officials for violating the right to free speech;

17. **Proposes** the implementation of bodyguards from every part of the world for journalists, that will:

- a. take a test, composed to certify different physical aptitudes and mental fortitude, in order to be chosen by the Committee to Protect the Journalists (CPJ) as the ones who will go with the media workers on the field,
- b. sign a National Democratic Alliance (NDA) that obligates the bodyguard to a moral code established by each country and privacy towards each mission and report, as well as private information about the journalists,
- c. accompany and protect the media workers when they decide they want to operate in situations of armed conflict.